

HEADLAMP FOR FAMILIES · FIELD GUIDES

When the Readiness Assessment Says "Not Yet"

A guide for parents whose kid is not ready for their first device

A "not yet" result is not a failure. It is not a verdict on your kid's worth, maturity, or future. It is simply **feedback** — and it is much better to learn that now than after access has already created bigger problems.

When the Readiness Assessment Says "Not Yet"

If you've just gone through the readiness assessment with your kid and the result is clear — they are not ready yet for their own device — there's a good chance you're feeling two things at once.

Relief.

Something in you probably already sensed this. The assessment gave language to what you were already seeing at home.

And dread.

Because now you have to hold a boundary your kid may not like — especially if friends already have phones.

That discomfort is real — for parents and kids. But this is exactly where your leadership matters.

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A Typical Moment Many Parents Know Well

Imagine a 12-year-old in seventh grade. Several of her friends already have phones. Group chats are forming. Weekend plans are getting made faster than she can keep up. Her parents do the readiness assessment with her. The results confirm what they've already been seeing: she's bright and social, but still struggles to regulate strong emotions, forgets responsibilities without reminders, and has a hard time stopping when something is highly stimulating.

When she hears the result, she is crushed:

- " *That's not fair.*
- " *Everyone else has one.*
- " *You don't trust me. You don't understand how this works.*

Her parents feel torn. They don't want to shame her or damage the relationship — but they also don't want to give her something she's not ready to manage.

That is exactly where many families find themselves. And that is why this moment matters so much.

"Not Yet" Is a Path, Not a Rejection

Kids can handle disappointment much better when they can see a path forward. The conversation needs to shift — from a flat no into a clear direction.

✗ INSTEAD OF THIS

"You're not getting a phone because I said so."

✓ TRY THIS

"Here's what needs to grow before this becomes a wise next step."

That turns the device conversation into a **development conversation** — and that is exactly what it should be.

This Is Where Authoritative Parenting Shines

AUTHORITATIVE PARENTING

WARMTH

Responsiveness, empathy, and genuine connection — especially in hard moments when your kid is disappointed or upset.

FIRMNESS

Clear expectations and held boundaries — saying "I love you, I hear you, I understand — and I'm still going to lead."

Use the 4 S's to Guide the Conversation

Dan Siegel's framework for secure attachment is incredibly helpful here. When delivering a "not yet" result, aim to help your child feel all four:

S

Safe

This is not an attack. Your home is still a safe place to be disappointed, frustrated, or upset.

S

Seen

"I know this feels big. I know it's hard when friends already have one." Being seen means feeling understood, not getting what they want.

S

Soothed

Stay grounded. Don't match their intensity. Your steadiness helps regulate their nervous system.

S

Secure

Security comes from knowing your love is not changing even when the answer is no. A clear boundary can actually strengthen security over time.

Be Clear About What Growth Looks Like

If your kid is not ready, they need more than a no. They need a picture of what growth looks like. Be

Tie Readiness to Real Responsibilities

The best way to help executive functioning grow is not through lectures — it is through reps. Give your kid real chances to practice responsibility in daily life:

- ◆ Waking up on time without repeated intervention
- ◆ Managing homework with less hovering
- ◆ Completing chores that genuinely matter to the family
- ◆ Staying calm and respectful when disappointed
- ◆ Keeping track of belongings and commitments
- ◆ Recovering more quickly after emotional upset

These are the experiences that build the internal capacities a kid will need when a device is in their hand.

Don't Hand Them a Phone to Solve the Problems That Show They're Not Ready

A kid struggles with boredom, emotional outbursts, or self-management — and the phone starts to look like the solution. It keeps them busy. It calms them down. It helps them fit in. But:

⚠ WATCH FOR THIS TRAP

A phone often doesn't solve developmental gaps — it covers them up while making them harder to address. If your kid needs to grow in executive functioning or emotional regulation, those are the exact muscles that need more practice *before* device access expands.

Model What Healthy Device Use Looks Like

If you want your kid to build a healthy relationship with technology, they need to see one — imperfect, but intentional. Let your kid see you:

- Put your phone away during conversations
- Resist checking every notification
- Choose boredom sometimes
- Protect sleep from screens
- Be fully present at meals
- Admit when your habits need work

Your example tells your kid: *this is a way of living we are trying to practice as a family.*

"I get that this is disappointing. I know this is hard. I'm not punishing you."

"This is about readiness, not worth. We are for you — and we are going to help you grow toward this."